

CHAPTER 1

The rains came late that year, and the whole valley waited for them with the patience of people who have waited before.

Nobody in the settlement said so aloud, but the elders had begun to measure the grain differently, and the children noticed.

It was a small thing, the way a hand hesitates over a measure, and yet it travelled through the households faster than any announcement.

By the second week of the dry spell the river had narrowed to a bright thread, and the women walked further each morning to reach it.

CHAPTER 2

By the second week of the dry spell the river had narrowed to a bright thread, and the women walked further each morning to reach it.

Ndungu kept the ledger, as his father had, in a book whose spine had been repaired three times with the same waxed thread.

He wrote in a hand so small that the pages seemed to contain no writing at all until you brought a lamp close to them.

Everything in the settlement passed through those pages eventually: the debts, the marriages, the goats sold at the crossroads market.

CHAPTER 3

Everything in the settlement passed through those pages eventually: the debts, the marriages, the goats sold at the crossroads market.

“You write too much,” his wife told him, not unkindly, and he answered that a thing unwritten is a thing already half forgotten.

The truth was more ordinary. He wrote because the writing steadied him, the way other men were steadied by walking or by prayer.

In the fourth month the rains arrived all at once, without ceremony, and washed a section of the eastern road entirely away.